

University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab - Appropriate Usage Agreement

March 20, 2025

Introduction

The computing resources at the University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab are designed to support the educational, instructional, and research activities related to digital forensics tools, techniques, and methodologies. Access to these resources, including virtual machines (VMs) and forensic software, is a privilege extended to students enrolled in the Cyber Forensics Program. As a user of these services and facilities, you have access to advanced forensic tools and methods that could potentially cause harm if misused or applied with malicious intent. By using Cyber Forensics Lab computing devices and VMs, you acknowledge and agree to abide by the **University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab - Appropriate Usage Agreement**. This agreement requires you to act in a responsible, ethical, and legal manner at all times.

You are authorized to access and utilize forensic tools and VMs provided to you solely within the lab environment (e.g., designated Cyber Forensics Lab rooms at the University of Baltimore) and under the direct supervision or instruction of your professor or lab instructor. This agreement mandates that you respect the rights of other Cyber Forensics Lab users, maintain the integrity of the physical and virtual facilities, and adhere to all relevant software licenses and contractual agreements.

Additionally, all users accessing the University of Baltimore's networks or IT resources, including wireless access with personal devices, are subject to the University's **Acceptable Use Policy** (published at www.ubalt.edu/aup, or refer to the official university IT policy page). Any violation of this policy may result in disciplinary actions, including restricted or revoked network privileges, suspension, or termination from the University. Violations of this Cyber Forensics Lab Usage Agreement may lead to expulsion from a Cyber Forensics course and/or a failing grade.

Appropriate Usage Guidelines

1. **Authorized Access:** You may only use the computers, VMs, accounts, and files for which you have been explicitly authorized. Unauthorized use of resources is prohibited.
2. **Account Security:** You may not use another individual's account, attempt to capture or guess passwords, or otherwise compromise the security of lab resources without explicit authorization from an instructor.

3. **Individual Responsibility:** You are solely responsible for the appropriate use of your assigned computer, VM, account, and all associated resources.
4. **License Compliance:** The University of Baltimore is bound by contractual and licensing agreements for forensic tools and third-party resources (e.g., forensic software). You are required to comply with these agreements when using such resources.
5. **Lab Environment Restrictions:** Forensic tools and VMs may only be used within the designated University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab environment and must not be deployed outside these areas or on the broader University network unless explicitly authorized.
6. **Network Boundaries:** You must not attempt to access areas of the University network beyond the Cyber Forensics Lab (e.g., campus network, wireless systems), monitor network traffic, or interact with external systems without explicit approval from an instructor.
7. **Prohibited Activities:** You must not develop or use programs, scripts, or processes that disrupt other users, damage VMs, or degrade the performance of lab hardware/software without prior approval. This includes any unauthorized forensic analysis or intrusive activities (e.g., hacking) within or outside the lab environment.
8. **VM Usage:** VMs provided in the lab are pre-configured for forensic analysis and must not be modified, copied, or removed from the lab environment without permission. Any evidence or data generated within VMs must be handled according to lab protocols to maintain chain of custody and integrity.
9. **Software Installation, System Modifications, and Privilege Escalation:** Users are strictly prohibited from:
 - Installing unauthorized software.
 - Uninstalling, modifying, deleting, or tampering with system files, settings, or configurations on lab computers or VMs.
 - Attempting privilege escalation, including but not limited to the use of “sudo” and “su” commands, administrative commands, or bypassing permission controls, except when explicitly directed by authorized lab instructors.

Exceptions to these restrictions require prior written approval from an instructor or the University of Baltimore Office of Technology Services (OTS).

Consequences of Non-Compliance

Violation of this policy will result in immediate account deactivation and may lead to further disciplinary action, including but not limited to restricted or revoked lab privileges, course expulsion, a failing grade, suspension, or termination from the University of Baltimore. Additionally, legal consequences may apply for violations of state or federal laws.

Acknowledgment

By accessing and using University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab computing devices and VMs, you acknowledge and agree to comply with the **University of Baltimore Cyber Forensics Lab - Appropriate Usage Agreement**. This agreement ensures that all activities within the lab are conducted responsibly, ethically, and in accordance with University policies and applicable laws.